appealed with some success, that liquidation would be a “national disaster”.’[33]

Whatever the actual financial position of SSNCo and the differences among the directors, Pandithurai Thevar and his line of thinking had carried the day. The company was not giving up without a fight.

Trimming the Sails

The financial crisis faced by SSNCo following the stormy months of January to March 1908 is more than evident from the accounts that the government accessed covertly and the official reports presented at the shareholders’ meeting. Serious operational and financial difficulties plagued the company despite its near monopoly over the cargo shipped from Tuticorin. While the annual report presents an overall picture, granular details can be garnered from police intelligence and newspaper reports. Much can be deduced with the government constantly monitoring the company—even more closely than its shareholders, one could say. Reports in the nationalist press complement the picture and provide a much-needed corrective to official prejudice.

The primary concern was the outstanding payments for the purchase of the ships—a substantial Rs 93,425-12-0 and sundry creditors from whom Rs 1,72,020-0-1 had been borrowed to purchase steamers and meet related expenses. But the exact amounts due are not clear with records mentioning conflicting sums, the number of instalments and due dates.

P.B. Thomas observed that Rs 50,000 was owed on each steamer.[34] Citing a *Madras Standard* report, *Swadesamitran* said, in late March, that a last instalment of Rs 47,000 was due on the *Gallia* and that K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar had intervened to get an extension thereby averting a disaster for the company.[35] In mid-April 1908, the deputy superintendent of police, Tuticorin informed the government that, of the two steamers one was ‘a very old boat and the other a boat only three years old but sold cheap on account of defective construction’ and that Rs 70,000 was still due.[36]